

***General Knowledge***  
***Ancient History***

**STUDY NOTES**

**Indus Valley Civilization**



# Indus Valley Civilization



## Introduction

- The Indus Valley Civilization is the earliest known urban culture in the northwestern part of the Indian subcontinent.
- Recognized as one of the world's first three civilizations, alongside Mesopotamia and ancient Egypt, it flourished from approximately **3300 BCE to 1300 BCE**.
- Its development was significantly influenced by geographic factors such as fertile soil, favorable climate, and distinct physical landscapes.
- Early discoveries, including sites like Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro within the Indus Valley, lent the civilization its name.
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- Later discoveries of sites like **Kalibangan, Lothal, and Rakhigarhi** showed similar characteristics.
- Since Harappa was the first site excavated, this civilization is also referred to as the **Harappan Culture**.

## The Indus Valley Civilization's Origin and Discovery

- In the basin of the Indus River, the Indus civilization developed from settlements that practiced irrigated agriculture according to the Mesopotamian model.

- **Origin:** One of the earliest areas on the Indian subcontinent where people settled and developed a highly civilized way of life was the Indus Valley.
  - It is also referred to as the Indus-Sarasvati Civilization, while its modern name is derived from its location in the valley of the Indus River.
- **Discovery of IVC:** In **1924**, **John Marshall** announced to the world the existence of an ancient civilisation in the Indus Valley.
  - The first person to come across Harappa was **Charles Masson**, who identified it as an ancient city called Sangala, belonging to the time of Alexander.
  - Excavating the ruins in the early twentieth century revealed their full significance. Daya Ram Sahni excavated **Harappa in 1920**, and **Rakhaldas Banerjee** excavated **Mohenjo-daro in 1921**.
- **Geographical Factors:** The Indus Valley must have had perfect geographic conditions for human growth and settlement. This area is now too arid to support human habitation.
  - Figures of a wide range of plants and animals that can only survive in rather moist environments have been discovered in Indus seals. Consequently, it is believed that the weather was fairly moderate.
  - Fertility was abundant in the broad plains bordering the Indus. Each year, the floods irrigated the farms and left behind rich alluvial soil on these plains
- Using radiocarbon dating, the civilization may be dated from 3300 BCE to 1300 BCE.
- The Harappan Civilization was divided into 4 phases:
  - Pre-Harappan
  - Early Harappan
  - Mature Harappan
  - Late Harappan

## Map of Indus Valley Civilization



- Indus sites are distributed across a large area in India and Pakistan.
- Geographically, the civilization extended outside the Indus zone.
- It was made up of riverine lowlands that spread east and southeast into Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, highlands and coastal parts in Balochistan, and a coastal strip in Gujarat.
- **Area:** It encompassed an area of approximately 1,299,600 square km.
- It covered a considerably broader region than the ancient Egyptian or Mesopotamian cultures did.

## Sites of Indus Valley Civilization

- The Indus Valley Civilization, situated in the river basins of the Indus and Ghaggar-Hakra, featured several key cities such as **Mohenjo-Daro, Harappa, Kalibangan, Lothal, Rakhigarhi, Chanhudaro, Banawali, Dholavira, etc.**
- It extended from Sutkagendor (in Balochistan, Pakistan) in the West to Alamgirpur (UP) in the East; and from Mandu (Jammu) in the North to Daimabad (Maharashtra) in the South.

## Major Indus Valley Sites

| Sites                                                                                                                           | Location (Present)                          | Important Findings                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Harappa</b><br><b>(2600-1900 BCE)</b><br> | Punjab province of Pakistan<br>(Ravi River) | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Excavated By: <b>Dayaram Sahani</b> in 1921</li> <li>• It is situated on the bank of river <b>Ravi</b> in the</li> <li>• Montgomery district of Punjab (Pakistan).</li> </ul> <p><b>Important Findings:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Sandstone statues of <b>Human Anatomy</b></li> <li>• Gateway city and a meeting point of several routes.</li> <li>• Granaries</li> <li>• Bullock carts</li> </ul> |

|                                                                                                                                  |                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                                  |                                                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Stone dancing Natraja</b></li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <p><b>Mohenjo-Daro</b><br/>(2500-1700 BCE)</p>  | <p>Sindh Province, Pakistan (Indus River)</p>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Excavated By: <b>R.D Banerjee</b> in 1922</li> <li>• It is situated on the Bank of river <b>Indus</b> in the <b>Larkana District of Punjab (Pakistan)</b>.</li> </ul> <p><b>Important Findings:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Great Bath</b></li> <li>• Collegiate Building and Assembly Hall</li> <li>• Granary</li> <li>• <b>Bronze dancing girl</b></li> <li>• unicorn seal</li> <li>• Cotton</li> <li>• <b>Pashupati Mahadeva Seal</b></li> <li>• The chief male deity in the Harappan Period was the <b>Pashupati Mahadeva (proto-Siva)</b> represented in seals as sitting in a <b>yogic posture</b> on a low throne and having <b>three faces and two horns</b>.</li> <li>• He is surrounded by <b>four animals-elephant, tiger, rhino and buffalo</b>.</li> </ul> |
| <p><b>Rakhigarhi</b></p>                      | <p>Hisar district, Haryana<br/>(Sarasvati River)</p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Excavated By: Amarendra Nath</b></li> <li>• Located in <b>Hisar district (Haryana)</b></li> </ul> <p><b>Important Findings:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Townships of land were surrounded by <b>burned brick houses and muck</b>.</li> <li>• An <b>effective drainage system</b> and good hygiene.</li> <li>• Mud bricks made up the granary, while rammed earth plastered with mud served as the floor.</li> <li>• A seal bearing an alligator emblem was found.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>Dholavira</b><br/>(3500-1800 BCE)</p>  | <p>Great Rann of Kutch, Gujarat</p>     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Discovered in 1968 by archaeologist <b>Jagat Pati Joshi</b></li> <li>Included in the list of World Heritage Sites list of UNESCO in <b>2021</b>.</li> <li>India's <b>40th World Heritage Site</b></li> </ul> <p><b>Important Findings:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Cities were composed of a lower town, a middle town, and a citadel.</li> <li>A series of water reservoirs cascade, and a lot of stone is used in the building.</li> <li>certain burial grounds.</li> <li>Redware and black on red ware ceramics.</li> <li>It is known as a lake city or a <b>jala durga (water fort)</b> because of its well-known and advanced water collecting system.</li> </ul> |
| <p><b>Lothal</b><br/>(2400-1600 BCE)</p>   | <p>Gulf of Khambhat region, Gujarat</p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Located in the <b>Bhāl region of Gujarat</b></li> </ul> <p><b>Important Findings:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>A city with a town on the upper and lower levels.</li> <li>There was a tidal <b>dockyard and a bead factory found</b>.</li> <li>Within the Indus Valley Civilization, it is the sole port town.</li> <li>The fire god was revered.</li> <li>Coffin usage at graveyards.</li> <li>Pottery made of black and red clay.</li> <li>Early evidence of rice farming in South Asia has been found in Lothal.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                          |
| <p><b>Kalibangan</b><br/>(3500 BC-2500 BC)</p>                                                                                | <p>Rajasthan, (Ghaggar River)</p>       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Discovered by <b>Amlanand Ghosh</b> in 1953.</li> </ul> <p><b>Important Findings:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Priest quarters</li> <li><b>Fire pits</b></li> <li><b>Plough marks</b></li> <li>Double cropping pattern</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
|  |  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Bronze bull</li> </ul> |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|-----------------------------------------------------------------|

## Other Important sites

| State          | Site      | Discovered By       | River       | Features                                                                                  |
|----------------|-----------|---------------------|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Haryana, India | Banawali  | R. S. Bisht (1974)  | Ghaggar     | Fortified town, terracotta figurines, evidence of cotton cultivation.                     |
|                | Mitathal  | Suraj Bhan (1968)   | Ghaggar     | Pottery kilns, evidence of two distinct Harappan phases, urban layout.                    |
| Gujarat, India | Surkotada | J. P. Joshi (1964)  | Drishadvati | Horse remains, fortified settlement, and evidence of copper objects.                      |
|                | Rangpur   | M. S.Vats (1931)    | Madar       | Evidence of rice cultivation, distinct pottery, and Harappan influence with local traits. |
|                | Bhagatrav | S. R. Rao (1953)    | Kim         | A Harappan port, bead-making factory, evidence of shell industry and trade.               |
|                | Desalpur  | P. P. Pandya (1963) | Khari River | Fortified Harappan township, pottery, evidence of military                                |

|                       |                    |                                              |                |                                                                                        |
|-----------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                       |                    |                                              |                | fortifications.                                                                        |
|                       | Rojdi              | <b>Gregory Possehl (1982)</b>                | Bhadra River   | Agricultural settlement, copper artifacts, unique burial practices.                    |
|                       | Bagasra            | <b>V. H. Sonawane (1996)</b>                 | Gulf of Kutch  | Evidence of shell industry, coastal trade, and late Harappan artifacts.                |
|                       | Gumla              | <b>Archaeological Survey of India (1983)</b> | Gulf of Cambay | Harappan port, trade links with Mesopotamia, evidence of shipbuilding.                 |
| Rajasthan, India      | Karanpura          | <b>V. N. Misra (1977)</b>                    | Luni River     | Harappan seals, terracotta figurines, agricultural tools, and early Harappan evidence. |
| Uttar Pradesh,        | Alamgirpur (East)  | <b>Y. D. Sharma (1958)</b>                   | Hindon River   | Evidence of late Harappan pottery, the site at the easternmost extent of IVC.          |
| Balochistan, Pakistan | Sutkagendor (West) | <b>Stein Aurel (1929)</b>                    | Dasht River    | Trade link between Harappa and Mesopotamia, a fortified town near the Arabian Sea.     |
|                       | Balakot            | <b>George Dales (1973)</b>                   | Arabian Sea    | Coastal settlement, evidence of shell working, trade links with the Gulf region.       |
| Maharashtra, India    | Daimabad (South)   | <b>B. K. Thapar (1958)</b>                   | Pravara        | Bronze sculptures are evidence of Harappan influence in the Deccan region.             |

|                 |               |                                              |        |                                                                                |
|-----------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jammu, India    | Manda (North) | <b>Archaeological Survey of India (1947)</b> | Chenab | Northernmost Harappan site, strategic location for trade, distinctive pottery. |
| Sindh, Pakistan | Chanhudaro    | <b>N. G. Majumdar (1931)</b>                 | Indus  | Bead-making factory, no citadel, evidence of craft production and trade.       |

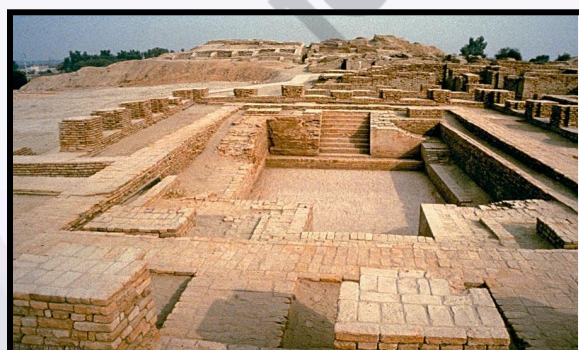
### Pictures of some of the shreds of evidence:



**Pashupati Seal**



**Dancing Girl (Bronze)**



**Great Bath**



**Fire pits**

## Features of IVC

### Livelihood:

Let's understand the living style of the people of the Indus Valley civilization.

#### • Food habits:

- Crops taken were Wheat and Barley primarily.
- Fruits: Pomegranates and bananas
- Non-veg: Meat and fish

#### • Costumes & ornaments:

- Clothes are mostly made of wool and cotton.
- **Women wore a short skirt**
- **Men wore a long piece of cloth around themselves.**
- Women had used bracelets and necklaces made up of **shells, gold and silver.**
- Men were used to wearing amulets to protect themselves from wrong influences.



**Ornaments**

#### • Amusements:

- Children used to play with small clay carts, dolls, rattles, marbles, etc.
- Figures of animals were made like puppets.
- Whistles were made in the form of birds.
- Old people used to enjoy gambling.

- **Occupations:**

- The weaving of clothes.
- Trading with the Persian Gulf and Sumerians.
- *Making of beads like clay, stone, paste, shell, and Ivory; and amulets.*
- Metalworks.

- **Trade:**

- Seals and small objects of Mohenjodaro were found in sites of Iraq.
- At Lothal dock, weights and measures have been found in various shapes and were accurate.
- Traces of trading with Afghanistan for *Blue gemstone and Lapis Lazuli*.

- **Religion:**

- People believed in god.
- Inscriptions of clay figures of **mother-goddess and seated figures of male gods** carved on a small stone seal. Eg. *the Pashupati seal*.
- They had few things believed to be sacred. Eg. *Peepal Tree seal, Horned Bull seal, etc.*



**Peepal tree trade seal**

- **Cremate system:**

- **3 types of burial systems were observed:**
  1. **Extended burial system:** The body was placed in North-South directions.

2. **Symbolic burial system:** Body couldn't found eg. Kaalibangan
  3. **Twin burial system:** Two bodies in one grave. eg. Man and Dog.
- Refer to image 5 under the Evidence heading.

## Art and Architecture:

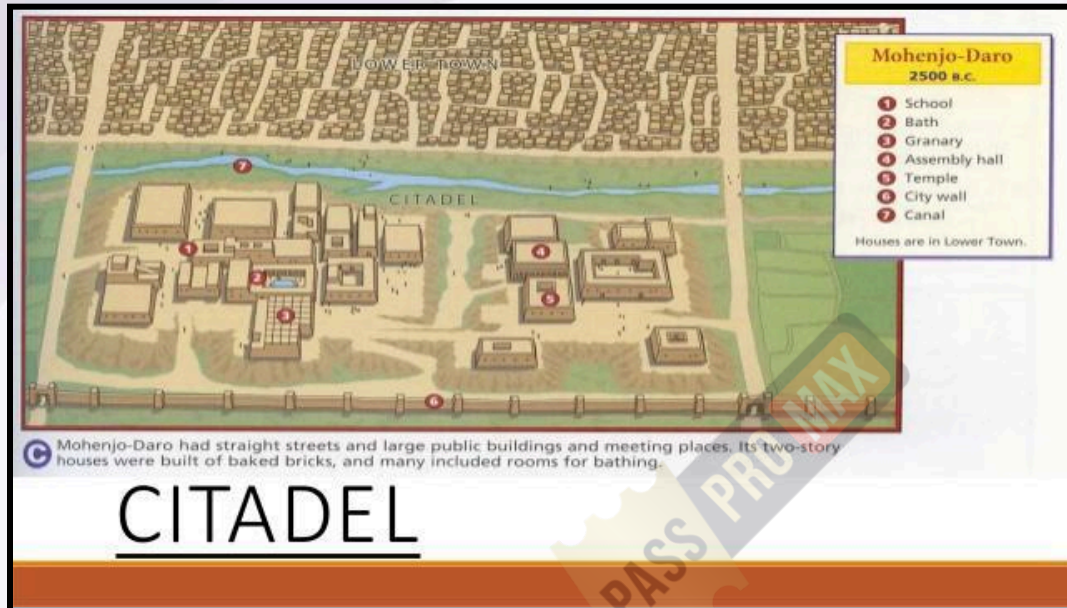
- **Architecture:**
- **Town Planning:**
- **Roads:**
  - **Rectangular grid pattern** planning.
  - Roads met at right angles.
  - The grid road is divided into small roads connected to the small lanes of the individual houses.



**A grid pattern of roads.**

- **Buildings:**
  - Dwelling houses, public buildings, and public baths.
  - Burnt mud bricks were used for the construction.
- **City Division:**
  - It was divided into the *upraised citadel* and the lower part into the west and east sides respectively.

- **Upraised citadel** composed of It consists of granaries, administrative buildings, courtyards, and pillared halls.
- **Lower part:** small one-room quarters for working-class people, Public baths. Eg. Great Bath at the Mohenjodaro site.



- **Drainage System:**
  - Small drains from each house were connected to larger drains running alongside the main roads.
  - Drains were covered loosely to allow regular cleaning and maintenance.
  - Cesspits were placed at regular intervals.



**Drainage system**

- **Sculptures:**

- **Seals:**

- Seals were made of **Steatite, a soft stone** found in river beds.
- Seals **made of copper, gold, faience, ivory, and terracotta** were also found.
- **Shapes: square, triangular, rectangular, and circular.**
- Inscriptions were written in pictographic **language** from **right to left**.
- Some seals have an impression of animals eg. Bull.
- Some seals have an impression of half man and half animal. Eg. *the Pashupati seal*.
- **Use: primarily for trade, identification marks, or educational purposes.** Eg. *Seals have mathematical images like Swastik on it.*



Trade seals

- **Bronze figures:**

- **Cire perdue technique** is also known as a **lost wax method** used to make **bronze figures**. In this technique, holes are made to fill the liquid metal. After drying the wax is removed from a metal structure.
- *Dancing girl: Tribhanga posture*, is one of its makings. (Refer: To image 2 in the evidence heading.)

- **Terracotta:**

- Use of fire-baked clay for making sculptures.
- Use: make toys, animal figures, miniature carts, and wheels, etc.

- **Pottery:**

- Excavation sites found **2 kinds of pottery: plain pottery and painted pottery**.
- **Painted pottery** also called **Red and Black pottery** in which *red color is used in the background and black color is used to draw designs and figures on it.*

- Trees, birds, animal figures, and geometrical patterns were some of the themes.
- All are wheel-made decorative potteries.
- Use: household purposes, decorative purposes, and liquor pouring.



Potteries

- **Stone figures:**

- The skill of craftsmanship was at its best.
- Eg. **Bearded priest** stone figure: draped in a shawl with trefoil patterns. The eyes are elongated and half-closed as in meditation.
- The **red sandstone figure of the male torso** is another example.



Beared priest

## Fall of Harrappans:

- Around 1500 B.C., the fall of the Harappan civilization was predicted. It was the same period that is considered the arrival of Aryans.
- The various **prediction theories** were made as follows:
  1. **Massive flood to Indus River** which led to the drowning of cities. (**The movie Mohenjodaro by Ashutosh Govarikar used this reference at the end of the film**). Another disastrous change in the Harappan climate might have been **eastward-moving monsoons** or winds that bring heavy rains. Monsoons can be both helpful and detrimental to a climate, depending on whether they support or destroy vegetation and agriculture.
  2. One theory suggested that a nomadic, Indo-European tribe called the **Aryans invaded** and conquered the Indus Valley Civilization.
  3. Some experts believe the **drying of the Saraswati River**, which began around 1900 BCE, was the main cause of climate change led to a massive **drought for many years**.
  4. Some say **due to droughts there were famines**.
  5. The **pandemic disease was predicted (like COVID-19 today)** which eliminated the human race.
  6. By 1800 BCE, the Indus Valley climate grew cooler and drier, and a tectonic event may have diverted or **disrupted river systems**, which were the lifelines of the Indus Valley Civilization. **The Harappans may have migrated toward the Ganges basin in the east, where they could have established villages and isolated farms.**
- But, there is **no conclusive evidence yet**.